

hard truth you can unearth at this stage of the game, the more heartbreak you'll spare yourself in the future.

1. At a romantic dinner for two, your partner:

- a) Reaches for his wallet during dessert and comes up empty-handed, then asks sheepishly if you can cover it “just this once.” It’s the third time he’s asked this month. To make matters worse, he tells the server his steak was undercooked and demands to see the manager for a refund—even though he’s already eaten half of it.
- b) Orders the most expensive bottle of wine in the restaurant. He insists that you get an appetizer *and* dessert, even though you’re not that hungry, and orders you a tawny port after the meal, even though you’d rather not drink. Per usual, he insists on paying for everything—with his credit card.
- c) Wears sandals and surfer shorts. He spends most of the meal talking about his budding career as an artist—never mind that he isn’t actually making any art or selling any of it. When you ask him about the job interviews he mentioned earlier, he shrugs off the question, telling you for the 15th time, “I can’t go corporate. It’s just not part of my vision.”
- d) Sees an old school acquaintance and tries to engage him/her in conversation. But the old friend isn’t exactly friendly. You get the sense that he/she doesn’t look kindly on your partner and looks at you with an expression that says, “Cut your losses, fast.” When you try to ask the acquaintance about your date, your date interrupts the conversation and sends the friend on his way.